
One of the Olympics' Biggest Stars Is at the Center of a Bizarre Intra-Squad Drama

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[Olympics Jerk Watch](#) is a long-running feature that subjectively rates the jerkiness (or lack thereof) of the Games' biggest stars. Read more of Slate's 2026 Olympics coverage [here](#).

Nominee: Julia Simon

Home country: France

Known for: Winning biathlon medals, stealing a teammate's credit card, not taking full responsibility for stealing a teammate's credit card

Why she might be a jerk: Julia Simon is one of the top female biathletes in Europe, which makes her a figure of some renown on a continent where biathlon is the most popular winter sport. At the Milan Cortina Games, she lived up to her reputation, winning three gold medals and one silver. Before these Winter Games began, though, Simon made headlines for her performance in a very different field: [internecine credit-card fraud](#).

In 2022, while the French team was in Norway for a [summer biathlon festival](#), Justine Braisaz-Bouchet noticed that someone had used her credit card to make more than \$2,000 worth of online purchases. Getting a fraud alert is bad enough. But to make matters worse, Braisaz-Bouchet soon realized that the purchases had apparently been made by her biathlon teammate [and longtime rival](#): Simon. Ooh la la!

Braisaz-Bouchet filed charges in 2023. At the same time, Simon was having a banner year that ended with her winning the Crystal Globe, which is awarded by the International Biathlon Union to the season's best biathlete. French biathlon fans didn't necessarily want to hear that their biggest star was perhaps also a thief, and Braisaz-Bouchet [has said that](#) "for many people I was the troublemaker." Silent complicity in victim-blaming is pretty jerky.

Simon initially claimed that she was innocent, speculating that the *real* thief had perhaps stolen *her* identity as a form of camouflage, much like how O.J. Simpson was framed by the real killer. But further investigation revealed that Simon had *also* allegedly made unauthorized purchases with a team staffer's credit card. In October 2025, she was found guilty in a French court and was given a three-month suspended sentence and a five-figure fine. "I can't explain it. I don't remember doing it. I can't make sense of it," she said in court. Chalking it up to amnesia is something that only true jerks do!

After Simon's conviction, the French ski federation handed her a six-month ban, five months of which were conveniently suspended until after the Olympics. That means she'll be in real big trouble if she steals *another* teammate's credit card between now and mid-May. In effect, Simon got away scot-free, which seems like a pretty jerky outcome. After all, when Ruben Rivera stole Derek Jeter's mitt out of his locker during spring training and sold it to a memorabilia dealer for \$2,500, he was [kicked off the New York Yankees](#) and never appeared in the big leagues again. Now, nobody's saying that Simon deserved to be kicked off the Yankees, too. (That would be crazy, the Yankees are counting on her this year!) But shouldn't her ban have been substantial enough to stop her from competing in the Olympics?

The difference here, I suppose, is that Rivera has a .216 career batting average, while Simon is a star. If *Jeter* had stolen *Rivera's* glove, you can bet that the Yankees would've allowed their captain to compete in the World Series and/or the Olympic biathlon.

Similarly, the French ski federation didn't want to sideline one of the nation's medal hopefuls. They've been rewarded for that decision: As previously mentioned, Simon won four medals in the 2026 Games, two of them in team events. Has all that success for the French squad translated into *bonhomie*? "The page has been turned within the team—we have spoken about it," [Simon told Eurosport](#). Sounds convincing to me.

In her public-facing appearances during the 2026 Games, Simon hasn't seemed particularly repentant. To the contrary: After crossing the finish line in the women's 15-kilometer individual event, she held her finger to her lips in a "shushing" motion, [later saying in a press conference](#) that the gesture "was for one person, he knows it. We had a talk, so I won't [say] anything more about it. Yeah, it's over now." Kind of a jerk move not to tell the media who that "one person" is!

Why she might not be a jerk: Although I mocked Simon's "fugue state" defense in the preceding section, I suppose there is a world in which it holds water. Simon was in her early- to mid-20s when the offenses occurred. Sometimes, when young athletes face intense competitive pressures, they respond to those pressures in strange and unaccountable ways.

It is certainly possible that Simon wasn't in her right mind when she committed these crimes. Simon has said that she's been working with a therapist to try and understand what she did and why she did it. We might consider taking her words at face value: If these incidents *were* the result of some sort of untreated psychological problem, then maybe Simon deserves compassion more so than our reflexive scorn. It would probably help her cause, though, if she didn't make mocking hand gestures. Gesture-related mockery is the known province of jerks!

It could be that biathletes are just wired this way. [I already wrote about](#) the Norwegian who stole his victorious teammate's thunder by blurting out in a post-race interview that he had cheated on his girlfriend and was desperate to win her back. That guy, Sturla Holm Lægreid, finished the 2026 Games with *five* medals, one more than Simon. Way to show up *this* jerk, you jerk!

Also, last year another member of the French biathlon team was caught tampering with her teammate's rifle, [in what the Independent called](#) "a gross attempt to steal points at [the teammate's] expense." Who knows, maybe there's just something about biathlon that attracts these kinds of people?

Well, at least they don't have guns! (Takes a five-minute break to learn more about biathlon.) Well, at least they only have guns part of the time!

Jerk score: As a reminder, we score our jerk candidates on style, technical merit, and execution. I'll give Julia Simon 2.5 out of 3 points for style, because it would have been slightly jerkier for her to make a "swiping a credit card" gesture upon victoriously crossing the finish line. 2 out of 3 points for technical merit, because a Norwegian summer biathlon festival sounds like a very pleasant venue for credit-card fraud. 2 out of 3 points for execution, because she could have also stolen her teammate's traveler's checks. And 1 out of 1 points because it was very jerky of her not to buy me anything with her teammate's credit card. 7.5 out of 10 points for Julia Simon. Next!

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